

2.1.5 Servers

A server is basically a program that runs on a machine and provides a specific service to all machines that are connected to it. The server has a specific set of programs that allows the connected computers (called clients) to make different kinds of requests to it.

Think of a server as a waiter in a restaurant standing by to give you all he can accommodate on a tray. If, however, he doesn't have the item you wish to consume, he re-routes your order to another waiter (with different goodies) who happens to be waiting at another table. This other waiter passes on the object of desire via other waiters so it finally ends up on your plate.

A Web server is a machine that hosts Web sites and allows Internet users (clients) to access these sites. A Web server is basically the kind of server that holds static companies and just waits around for requests to come around from other machines on the Internet. Once it receives a request, it allows access to the data requested.

Web servers are the principal part of the Web, and every URL you request usually ends up at a Web server—unless a proxy server decided that it can help speed up the process by sending you the data itself.

- A file server is a machine that keeps files and allows clients to upload and download them from it.
- A proxy server sits between a client application, such as a Web browser, and a real server. It intercepts all requests to the real server, sees if it can fulfil the request from any of the recent requests, and if it can't, forwards the request to the server that actually hosts the Web site.
- A groupware server is software designed to enable users to collaborate, regardless of location, via the Internet or a corporate intranet and to work together in a virtual atmosphere.
- Mail servers move and store mail all across the Internet, and you have been "served" by one when you've checked your mail.
- A chat server allows you to interact with other users on the network in real-time.
- Integral to the process of sending data across the Internet is the Domain Name Server ("the DNS").

2.1.5 The Process Explained—Roughly

To give you a rough sketch of a smooth process, this is what happens when you log on to the Net and type in a URL. The browser